

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Nahum

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No one likes being in the path of a disaster, and the threat of enemy invasion is frightening. Can God protect us in these situations? Will God judge evil attackers? The prophet Nahum's reply is a clear yes.

Nahum's prophecy assures us that God still controls earth's history. His messages are a warning to oppressors and a comfort to the oppressed.

Setting

During Nahum's lifetime, the kingdom of Judah faced danger from the powerful Assyrian Empire. Its capital city, Nineveh, was ruled by King Ashurbanipal. He ruled from 668 BC to 626 BC. Under his rule, Assyria reached the height of its power. Its army and culture influenced much of the ancient Near East. Even the famous city of Thebes had been conquered by Assyria (3:8-10).

These events discouraged Nahum and the people of Judah. Israel, the northern kingdom, had already fallen to Assyria in 722 BC. Judah now faced the same threat. Matters became worse when Ashurbanipal captured Judah's wicked king, Manasseh. Manasseh ruled from 697 BC to 642 BC. Ashurbanipal took him to Babylon (2 Chronicles 33:10-11).

After his release, Manasseh repented (2 Chronicles 33:12-17) and tried to undo the evil he had done earlier (2 Kings 21:1-18; 2 Chronicles 33:1-9). Even so, the effects of his sins still remained throughout the land. God's people lived with fear and a sense of coming judgment. Because of this, Nahum's message about Nineveh's fall and Judah's future hope came at the right time.

At the same time, Assyria was already beginning to weaken. After Ashurbanipal defeated enemies in the west and overcame his brother's attempt to take the throne, he focused more on literature and art. As a result, the affairs of the empire suffered. After Ashurbanipal died in 626 BC, many important Assyrian cities fell to invading armies. Finally, in 612 BC, Nineveh itself was destroyed, just as Nahum had predicted.

Summary

Nahum begins his prophecy with two poetic passages that describe God's power (1:2-6 and 1:7-11). These poems show both God's judgment against evil and his

goodness toward those who trust him. The opening verses assure readers that God judges fairly.

Nahum then explains how God's justice works in history (1:12-15). No nation is too powerful to escape judgment for its evil actions. God sees the suffering of oppressed people. Nahum tells Judah that better days are coming. Peace and stability will return, and God's people will again worship him without interruption.

After predicting the attack on Nineveh and the restoration of Judah (2:1-2), Nahum gives two vivid descriptions of Nineveh's fall (2:3-10; 3:1-7). Between these descriptions, he includes a short song that mocks Nineveh. With sharp satire (the use of humor or ridicule to expose evil), Nahum announces that God will destroy the city's greed and pride (2:11-13).

Nahum continues with another satire about Nineveh. The city would be no safer than Thebes, the Egyptian capital that Assyria had already destroyed (3:8-13). The book ends with another mocking passage (3:14-19). Nahum taunts Nineveh's people by urging them to gather all their strength and resources to defend themselves. But it will not help. Nineveh will fall, and no one will rescue or mourn the city.

Author

Very little is known about Nahum apart from what appears in this book. In the Hebrew text, he is called "Nahum the Elkoshite" (1:1). Elkosh could be the name of his family group, but it was more likely his hometown in southwest Judah. The details in the book show that Nahum knew much about the city of Nineveh.

Date

Nahum mentions the fall of Thebes in 663 BC (3:10) and predicts the fall of Nineveh in 612 BC. This means his prophecies were spoken sometime between those years. Scholars debate the exact date.

Nahum may have prophesied late in the reign of King Manasseh, around 648-645 BC, possibly after Manasseh returned from captivity and began reforms (2 Chronicles 33:12-16). Or Nahum may have spoken later, during the early or middle years of King Josiah's reign. Josiah was king from 640 to 609 BC.

Meaning and Message

No empire, no matter how powerful, is beyond God's judgment. In time, every nation and every person must answer to the Lord for their actions. Nahum teaches that God rules over all the earth with righteous justice. He cares for people who suffer from war, violence, and

oppression. Those who carry heavy burdens can trust that God's justice will finally win.

God is patient and slow to anger (1:3). God's people are also called to live patiently and faithfully. The Lord is good and cares for those who trust in him (1:7). God has a purpose for his people (2:2), and this gives them hope.

Although Nahum contains strong warnings, it also brings good news (1:15). The prophet looks forward to a day when God's people will worship him again in peace and joy. They will no longer suffer under cruel rulers.

Later writers in Scripture saw Nahum's message of good news as pointing forward to the good news of Jesus Christ (Romans 10:15; see also Isaiah 52:7). Through Christ, people can be delivered from sin. The warning of Nineveh's destruction reminds believers that those who reject Christ face an even greater judgment. This truth encourages Christians to share the good news of salvation and eternal life with the world.